

ASSEMBLY POLLS
WEST BENGAL

Two opponents, travelling down the same stretch of road, but on somewhat opposite trajectories. That was Mamata Banerjee, leader of the Trinamool Congress (TMC) and incumbent chief minister of West Bengal, and Suvendu Adhikari, her erstwhile protégé and now the face of the BJP in Bengal, on their way to Bhabanipur—Suvendu on April 2 and Mamata six days later. This is the electoral arena where they are set to fight a duel on April 29. The disciple has proved a point before, defeating his mentor on his home turf Nandigram in 2021, and he is determined to reprise the act, this time in Mamata's own backyard. She, in turn, is projecting herself not just as the defender of Bengali identity, but also as a victim and a lone crusader, pitted against the combined institutional might of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Union government led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. "A total of 19 states and the Centre have come together against me...," she asserts in rally after rally. "I will continue my fight for the common people."

Suvendu's April 2 procession to Survey Building, the district electoral office where he filed his nomination, only served to prove her point. A travelling spectacle, it had Union home minister Amit Shah, Suvendu and Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya cover the 1.7 km stretch on a decorated vehicle, with cultural performances en route. The crowd was not just local; supporters had been mobilised from Purba Medinipur, Howrah and Ghatal. Mamata, by contrast, just stepped out of her residence, located roughly a kilometre from Survey Building, on April 8, walked the distance, accompanied not by any drama but just a few close aides. Her crowd was smaller, but overwhelmingly local.

Building Brand Mamata

Mamata is presenting this election not just as a bid for power but for political survival against overwhelming odds, an embattled sovereign defending her realm. She has resisted the BJP's advances in Bengal before, including during the 2021 assembly polls—when the TMC won 215 out of Bengal's 294 seats—and in the 2024 general election, in which she reduced the BJP's 2019 tally of 18 to 12 out of 42 seats. An encore this time would make her India's longest-serving woman chief minister, surpassing Sheila Dixit; it will also pave the way for her becoming the most powerful Opposition leader ahead of the 2029 general election.

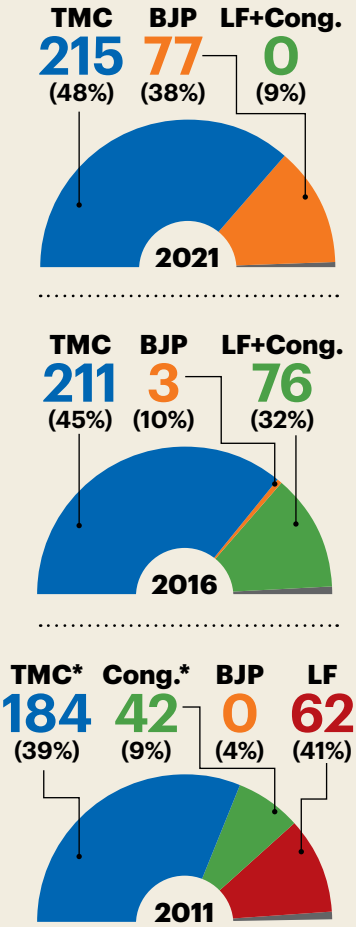
But first she must conquer anti-incumbency, resentment over recruitment scams and concerns over women's safety—especially in the aftermath of the 2024 rape and murder of student doctor 'Abhaya' at the R.G. Kar Medical College and Hospital—alongside the perennial issues of unemployment, lack of civic amenities and absence of industrial growth. Yet crowds continue to gather in large numbers at her rallies, particularly in rural Bengal, where the mere sight of Mamata's helicopter stirs a frenzy. She remains 'Didi' to them, an elder sister who will work for their welfare and fight for their rights.

Mamata has always framed electoral contests as battles to save the soul of Bengal, and herself as the embodiment of Bengali identity, which, she alleges, the 'outsider' BJP is out to reshape. The predominantly North Indian Hindutva party, the TMC asserts, won't spare even the culinary culture of the *machhe-bhate* Bengali (fish and rice-eating Bengali), likely to impose vegetarianism on them if it comes to power. Mamata, by contrast, pitches a more inclusive slogan: "*Je lorche sobar daakey, se jetabey Bangla Maa ke.*" The one who fights for all will ensure the victory of Mother Bengal.

The TMC leader reinforces her victim narrative with multiple other strands, from the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, the transfer of top police brass ahead of the election, to the attempt to introduce a delimitation bill amid elections. The last, Mamata alleges, is a conspiracy

PAST BATTLES

Total seats: **294**



**TMC & Cong. were in alliance in 2011*
Coloured numbers denote seats won; vote share in (); LF: Left Front